

Ethics: A Historical Perspective

- Introduction to the historical development of ethics
- Key thinkers and ideas
- Relevance of ethical theories today

Purpose of Studying Ethical History

- Understand foundations of ethical thought
- Appreciate systematic moral reasoning
- Apply classical ideas to modern dilemmas

Periods in Western Ethical Thought

- Classical Period (500 BC – AD 500)
- Medieval Period (500 – 1500)
- Modern Period (1500 – present)

The Classical Period: Context

- Transition: Rise of Greek city-states
- Change of old values: Shift from tradition to reason
- Spiritual counter part of medicine: Ethics as care of the soul

Sophists and Moral Relativism

- Morality as convention or social agreement
- Good and evil as social constructs
- Emphasis on convenience

Socrates (469–399 BC)

- Father of Western philosophy
- Morality grounded in reason: Reject the idea of tradition
- 'The unexamined life is not worth living'

Socratic Teaching Method

- Know thyself: Question-and-answer dialogue; and further inquiry
- Clarifying concepts like justice and virtue
- Linking facts and values

I to die, and you to live which of these two is better only God knows.

Plato (427–347 BC)

- Student of Socrates
 - The Republic: Intellectual pursuits is more desirable than personal pleasures
- Contrast to the idea of Socrates-Argued for the rule of moderation
- Reality of Ideas or Forms

Plato's Ethical Vision

- The Good as the highest reality
- Reason over bodily pleasure
- Ethical goal: vision of the Good

Aristotle (384–322 BC)

- Student of Plato
- Reject the theory of forms or ideas
- First systematic ethical theory

Aristotle's Ethics

- Happiness through reason
- Virtue as the mean
- Ethics rooted in daily life

Other Classical Schools

- Hedonism: Cyrenaics & Epicureans
- Duty and reason: Cynics & Stoics

The Medieval Period: Context

- Dominance of Christianity
- Ethics centered on God
- Reason combined with faith

St. Augustine (354–430)

- Christian-Platonic ethics
- Earthly vs eternal good
- Faith essential for virtue

St. Thomas Aquinas (1225–1274)

- Christianized Aristotle
- Natural and theological ethics
- Natural Law theory

Significance of Aquinas

- Harmony of reason and faith
- Ethics accessible through reason
- Path toward scientific ethics

The Modern Period: Context

- Reformation and scientific revolution
- Individual reasoning
- Shift from theology to science

Thomas Hobbes (1588–1679)

- Ethics based on self-interest
- Morality arises from social contract
- Authority ensures order

Reaction to Hobbes

- Humans possess moral faculty
- Concepts of intuition and conscience
- Morality beyond self-interest

David Hume (1711–1766)

- Moral judgment involves feeling
- Utility and pleasure
- Moral sentiment over pure reason

Immanuel Kant (1724–1804)

- Ethics of duty (Deontology)
- Basis of modern discussion of ethics
- Morality grounded in (pure) reason not in emotion
- 'Good will' as imperative of moral foundation
- Happiness will be achieved through reason.
- in a civilized society human beings considered as rational being
- Natural law as categorical imperativeness

Kant's Categorical Imperative

- Act according to universal law
- Treat humans as ends, not means
- Duty gives moral worth

John Stuart Mill (1806-1873)

- The ethics of consequences (Teleology)
- Inspiration from James Mill and Jeremy Bentham
- The system of Utilitarianism: Rightness or badness of action determined by their consequences
- It's a Hedonist ethics
- Pleasure or happiness is the standard of Moral Judgment

- External motivation: friends favour, or Gods wrath.
- Internal motivation: inner feeling of humanity
- From society we learn this inner motivation

Conclusion

- Ethical debates continue across eras
- Reason, duty, pleasure, and faith persist
- Historical ethics informs modern moral thinking